

The quest for Paris is on for Indian women's hockey

As the FIH Hockey Olympic qualifiers unfold in Ranchi, the **spotlight** is on the Indian women's team, which aims to secure a spot at the Summer Games in Paris.

Nihit Sachdeva
nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

SQUAD



Goalkeepers

Savita Punia (C)
Bichu Devi Kharibam

Defenders

Nikki Pradhan (VC)
Udita
Ishika Chaudhary
Monika

Midfielders

Nisha
Vaishnavi Vitthal Phalke
Neha
Navneet Kaur
Salima Tete
Sonika
Jyoti
Beauty Dungdung
Baljeet Kaur

Forwards

Lalremsiami
Sangita Kumari
Deepika

As the Olympic year kicks in, conversations about quotas, rankings, and qualification events across various disciplines will intensify.

Setting sights on securing a spot in the upcoming Summer Games in Paris from July 26 to August 11, the FIH Hockey Olympic qualifiers will be the first major event of 2024.

One of the two women's hockey qualification tournaments will be held at the Marang Gomke Jaipal Singh Stadium in Ranchi from January 13-19.

The event features eight teams in two groups — Group A comprises Germany, Japan, Chile, and the Czech Republic, while Group B features India, New Zealand, the USA, and Italy.

The top two sides from each group will progress to the semifinals. While the teams that reach the summit clash will automatically book a spot for the main event in Paris, the losing semifinalists will take on each other in a playoff to clinch the third and final spot.

Interestingly, this tournament was scheduled to take place in Changzhou, China, before the federations of both nations agreed to move it to India after The Snow Lotus secured Asian Games gold and, with it, the ticket to Paris.

China, coached by Australian legend Alyson Annan, had beaten India 4-0 in the semifinals of the continental event in front of the home



crowd in Hangzhou in October last year.

Since that loss, the Savita Punia-led Indian team has shown good form. It dominated the Asian Champions Trophy, held at the same venue where the Olympic qualifiers will take place, and won the title three weeks after securing bronze at the Asian Games.

While it could only manage one win — 2-1 against Ireland — in the